cabinet, including Gadi Eisenkot, Gantz, Gallant, and the top commanders, want to ease the situation of the Palestinian population. It is reported that Netanyahu will use a high-level conference this evening to criticize the chief of staff and the head of Shin Bet.

It remains unclear whether the ground operation in Gaza has reached the tunnels or whether the fighting remains on the streets. From well-informed sources, it seems that Hamas has managed to retain most of its military strength and that the IDF will need much more time if it aims at the thorough destruction of the terror organization. Getting the time needed may become difficult in view of international pressure and particularly American internal constraints. The solution could lie in tactical pauses in military operations that would allow more humanitarian aid to get to the population, without necessitating a general ceasefire that would seriously hamper pursuit of Israel's objectives. Hamas was apparently ready to liberate ten to fifteen hostages in exchange for a three-day pause in the fighting. Israel is asking for the release of many more hostages and a shorter pause.

I feel deeply depressed about the situation. From the information one can gather, Hamas is far from broken, and if we take an overall view, Israel is faced with a series of extremely difficult challenges that may already be influencing the general course of the war.

First, the families of hostages want the return of their loved ones to be a priority, but this probably doesn't fit the strategic goals of the IDF. It is often repeated that only military pressure will compel Hamas to liberate all the hostages, but things don't look that way. A general exchange of all the Palestinians kept in prisons by Israel for all of Hamas's hostages seems achievable, but it would mean a psychological and military success for Hamas. This option was rejected by Israel.

The lack of trust between Netanyahu and part of his coalition on the one hand, and the military and security heads on the other, is a second rift, felt